

PERENNIALS

One of the largest and most versatile plant groups, perennials offer a seasonally changing diversity of color, fragrance, form, and texture. The choice of perennials is vast, and there is a huge choice to suit any garden style, from traditional to modern.

What are perennials?

Perennials are nonwoody plants that live for two or more years and, when mature, produce flowers annually. The term often includes grasses and ferns. Although some perennials are evergreen, most are herbaceous and will die back each fall, emerging again in spring.

Choosing perennials

When making your selections, first check that the plants suit the climate, exposure, soil type, and light levels in your garden. Plants struggling in unsuitable conditions will not fulfill their intended purpose if they fail to flower or grow to fill their allotted space. The best results are usually achieved by grouping plants with similar

cultivation needs; you may also find inspiration for garden planting schemes by looking at natural landscapes for symbiotic planting groups. For example, a deciduous woodland may feature a range of shade-loving ferns that marry well together.

When perennials are massed together in borders, consider their eventual height and spread to ensure vigorous types do not overshadow or swamp more delicate plants.

Designing with perennials

Long herbaceous borders, often 10ft (3m) or more in depth, flanked by turf and backed by a wall or hedge, were traditionally planted with perennials

SIZE CATEGORIES USED WITHIN THIS GROUP		
Large over 4ft (1.2m)	Medium 2–4ft (60cm–1.2m)	Small up to 2ft (60cm)

that create a spectacular display in summer. Today, most people do not have space for such a scheme, and perennials are now more commonly used in smaller beds and borders with other plants, such as shrubs, bulbs, and annuals. However, the design ideas employed in these large borders can be used in more modest schemes, with tall plants sited at the back, midrange types in the middle, and compact perennials planted at the front, ensuring that all can be seen clearly and no plants are obscured by taller neighbors. Plants are grouped in swaths of three or more of the same species, which lends borders a visual unity and rhythm.

Groups of tall verbascums, eupatoriums, and delphiniums create a backdrop for the border plants in front, while low, ground-covering perennials such as *Cerastium tomentosum* and *Stachys byzantina* are ideal at the front. Superb effects can then be created by using large specimens as focal points, especially those that have an architectural form, such as cardoons (*Cynara cardunculus*) and bear's breeches (*Acanthus*), or a tall grass such as a miscanthus, or *Stipa gigantea*.

Introduce a variety of shapes and textures by combining the rounded forms of sedums, hylotelephiums, and geraniums with upright *Kniphofia* or salvias, for instance, or finely cut *Corydalis flexuosa* leaves with the bolder



ABOVE Frosted seed heads
Most perennials die down in winter, leaving borders bare, but a few, such as *Echinacea purpurea* 'Kim's Knee High' form decorative seed heads that remain for many months in winter.

LEFT Contrasting colors and forms
This design focuses on matching the blues and yellows of delphiniums, echinops, salvias, *Thalictrum flavum* subsp. *glaucum*, nepetas, verbascums, and foxgloves. Contrasting flower forms intensify the effect.